



Early gains: The 110-point run that Verstappen (in pic) had established early in the season, when Norris managed only 58 points, keeps the Dutchman ahead by 52 points. REUTERS

P1 finishes in 2024. After 10 long years, McLaren now leads the World Constructors' Championship (WCC), an accolade it last won in 1998.

So, what changed?

Given how McLaren started the season — just two podium finishes in five races — the sheer pace and performance that its MCL38 recently unleashed has raised eyebrows.

The car was given a significant revamp at the Miami GP, with major upgrades for Norris. While the 24-year-old's maiden F1 win there can't entirely be attributed to the modifications — since a timely Safety Car did help him — the subsequent results since then give more credence to the upgrade.

In the last 13 races, at least one of McLaren's drivers has finished in the top three, with the team having even secured double podium finishes in three races. Its average points scored per weekend surged from 19.2 to 32.3.

In the 18 races so far, McLaren has already doubled its podium count from 2023. Its drivers could get a best finish of only second place last season but this year it has stayed on

top not once, but five times, that too after a three-year drought.

In fact, McLaren concluded the 22-race 2023 season with 302 points, finishing fourth in the constructors' standings. But after three-quarters of this season, the Woking-based team holds the top spot with 516 points. Its average points per weekend also increased from 13.73 to 28.63.

Championship conundrum

A 41-point advantage may not guarantee McLaren the elusive Constructors' Championship, but the incredible performances of both drivers and the team's upward trajectory since Miami suggest otherwise.

McLaren has scored 420 points in the last 13 races, while its closest rival, Red Bull — which it overtook in the leaderboard after Piastri's win in Azerbaijan — has scored only 280, mostly through Verstappen.

If McLaren continues to gather solid points in the remaining races, the championship trophy could return to the eight-time winners. But this success might come at the cost of an ambitious, yet possible, WDC title for Norris, who currently sits second in the standings.

The British driver is having his best season yet and remains the strongest of the six drivers still capable of snatching the WDC from Verstappen. Whether Norris has caught up or

Verstappen has simply held on is hard to say, as both have scored identical points since round six — 221 each — with 11 podiums apiece.

The 110-point run that Verstappen had established early in the season, when Norris managed only 58 points, keeps the Dutchman ahead. Remarkably, the gap between them has remained at 52 points, despite Verstappen not claiming top honours since the Spanish GP in June.

Consistent top-10 finishes in every race thereon have helped Verstappen thwart any serious threat from Norris, who has been climbing the standings rapidly. At this rate, Verstappen could continue to offset the gains made by Norris, even if he finishes behind him.

Every additional point will count for McLaren's No. 1 driver if he wants to fight for the championship. In that case, Piastri may be expected to make way for him, which wouldn't be ideal if the team has its sights set on the constructors' title. Both drivers will likely be instructed to maximise points, regardless of who finishes ahead.

With only a quarter of the season remaining, all eyes are on the McLaren pit wall — will it focus on securing the constructors' championship, or will it allow its front-runner to chase the drivers' crown? It's all coming down to the wire!